

Making It Stick

*The whole play, act by act · Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir.
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Everyone seated · scripts and pencils · no staging yet

We have read the play twice — flat, then far too big. **Now we make it stick.** This is how we turn understanding into memory and get lines into heads the way that actually holds: by what the character wants, by the cue, and by testing ourselves — not by staring at the page. We work one act at a time across these evenings; the method is the same for all three.

How we learn lines — five rules

Learn by what you want, not by rote

A motivated line is half-learned. When you know what your character is *doing* to the other person in a line — I warn you, I beg you, I corner you — the words come because the intention comes. Lines learned as sound alone fall out under pressure; lines learned as actions hold.

Learn your cue, not just your line

The hardest thing to remember is the *other* person's last few words — that is what tells you to speak. Learn the cue and the line together, always. Half of “knowing the play” is knowing exactly when you come in.

Test yourself — don't re-read

Reading the scene over and over feels like learning and isn't. Read it a few times, then **close the book** and say it from memory; open only when you stick. Testing (active recall) builds far stronger memory than repetition.

Little and often — space it out

A scene that feels solid after one long session shows holes after a weekend. Ten minutes a day for a week beats an hour the night before. Space the same material across days and it sets.

The first-three-words rule

When you dry in a run, whoever is on book gives you only the **first three words** of the line — never the whole thing. You retrieve the rest yourself. Being handed the line teaches nothing; retrieving it is the memory forming.

The evening, step by step

18:00

Welcome & the frame

Seated. Say it plainly: *we know the play — tonight we make it stick and start getting it up. We turn understanding into memory: by intention, by cue, and by testing ourselves.*

18:10

Warm-up

Short seated voice and breath warm-up.

18:15	The method (5 minutes, then we use it) Walk the five rules opposite — learn by objective, learn the cue, test don't re-read, space it, first-three-words. Everyone will practise them tonight and take them home.
18:20	Units & actioning — the memory-maker On tonight's act, name the units and put one verb per thought (<i>I ____ you</i>), pencilled in. This is not separate from learning lines — chunked, motivated text is exactly what memory holds. Cover the whole play across these evenings, one act at a time.
19:00	The prompted cue-run Run the act script-in-hand but focused only on cue pick-up : the instant the cue lands, you are in — no gaps. On a dry, the prompter gives the first three words. This drills the joins, which is where runs fall apart.
19:20	Break Fifteen minutes. Rest the voice.
19:35	Off-book attempt — books down Put the scripts down for the section the company has learned furthest (Act One first). Run it; prompt with first-three-words only. This is the real test — and the fastest way to find the gaps while there is still time to close them.
20:00	The Father's arc / the act's spine Quick close-up on the evening's hardest thread — for Act One, the Father's control → injury → attack → horror . Knowing the shape makes the lines recall themselves in order.
20:20	The Italian speed-run The whole act, script in hand if needed, <i>as fast as humanly possible</i> — no emotion, no pauses, cues snapped up instantly. It welds the cues and the shape into the body and shows the act's true speed.
20:40	Set the plan & close Confirm who runs lines with whom this week, and the off-book date for this act. One sentence each: “ <i>I am trying to ____.</i> ”

How to learn your lines at home

1. Photocopy your scene. Read it aloud three times, thinking only about what you *want* in each line.
2. Cover your lines with a card. Read the cue, say your line from memory, then slide the card down to check. Repeat the scene until you get through it clean once.
3. Do it again the next day, and the next — ten minutes each. Spacing is what makes it stick.
4. Learn the **cue** with every line: whoever runs lines with you reads only the cues; you supply the lines.
5. Record the other parts (leave gaps for yours) on your phone and run it walking to work. Motion helps memory.
6. When you dry, get only the first three words — then retrieve the rest. Never read the whole line back.

Off-book timeline

Act One off book for the first staging call — it opens the August block

Act Two off book two weeks after Act One

Act Three off book two weeks after Act Two — the shortest, learned last

Whole play secure and running well before the first full run

The questions you ask

After the flat read of each part, put these to the characters who appear in it — one sentence each, in character. Answering them is also how the line gets learned: a line you know the reason for is a line you can recall.

ACT ONE

Part I — The Rehearsal

In it: The Manager, Player 1, Player 2, Player 3

The Manager

- What kind of day are you having before they walk in?
- What do you really think of the play you're forced to rehearse?
- What would make tonight a good night for you?

Player 1

- What do you think you're owed in this company?
- What was the best role you ever played — and how long ago?
- What are you afraid the others see when they look at you?

Player 2

- What keeps you patient with all of them?
- What do you do here that nobody thanks you for?
- What would you rather be doing?

Player 3

- What are you still excited about?
- What do you want to learn from the older two?
- What don't you understand about this job yet?

Part II — The Arrival

In it: The Father, The Step-Daughter, The Manager, the Players

The Father

- What do you need them to believe?
- Which story do you most want told — and why now?

The Manager

- When do you stop wanting to throw them out?
- What first makes you curious instead of angry?

The Step-Daughter

- Why sing “Valentine” to a room of strangers?

Part III — The Veil

In it: The Mother, The Father, The Step-Daughter

The Mother

- *What are you trying to stop from happening?*
- *Who are you most afraid for?*
- *Why can't you speak the way the others do?*

The Step-Daughter

- *What do you want them to see that the Father won't say?*
- *What has he done to you?*

Part IV — The Defence

In it: The Father, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, The Manager

The Father

- *What are you ashamed of that you'll talk around?*
- *When you look at the Step-Daughter, what do you feel?*

The Mother

- *What is the one sentence he can never talk you out of?*

The Step-Daughter

- *Why is being 'made pretty' worse than being ignored?*

Part V — The Hinge

In it: The Son, The Father, The Step-Daughter

The Son

- *Why don't you want to be here?*
- *What were you promised as a child that you never got?*
- *What would you do if you could just walk out?*

The Manager

- *What do you risk if you listen to them?*

Part VI — The Bargain

In it: The Father, The Manager, The Step-Daughter

The Father

- *What are you offering him — and what are you hiding?*
- *What can a stage give you that nothing else can?*
- *What happens to you if he says no?*

The Manager

- *What finally makes you say yes?*
- *What do you tell yourself to justify it?*
- *What are you already imagining the audience will think?*

The Step-Daughter

- *What are you afraid they'll make pretty?*
- *Which part of the story must they keep, no matter what?*
- *What do you want out of being watched?*

ACT TWO

Part I — The Setup

In it: The Step-Daughter, The Manager, The Mother, The Son

The Step-Daughter

- *In the shower speech, who are you really talking to?*
- *What do you feel for the little one — and for the boy?*
- *Why does getting the room exactly right matter so much?*
- *What do you wish you could undo?*

The Manager

- *What are you actually building out of these props?*
- *What excites you about this scene as theatre?*
- *What won't you let yourself feel about it?*

The Mother

- *What do you dread is coming?*
- *What do you want to say to your daughter and can't?*
- *What keeps you in the room when you want to run?*

The Son

- *What are you watching from the edge?*
- *What will you not be part of, and why?*

Part II — The Apparition

In it: Madame Pace, The Step-Daughter, The Father, The Mother

Madame Pace

- *What are you really selling?*
- *How do you see the girls who come to you?*
- *What makes you good at this — and how do you sleep at night?*
- *What do you want from the mother?*

The Step-Daughter

- *What is it like to watch this happen again?*
- *What did you feel walking into that room the first time?*
- *What do you want the Father to understand as he comes near?*

The Father

- *What do you tell yourself so you can walk into that shop?*
- *What do you see when you look at her there?*
- *When do you realise who she is — and what happens in you?*

The Mother

- *What finally breaks your silence?*
- *What have you known and refused to know?*
- *What do you want to do to Madame Pace?*

Part III — The Substitution

In it: Player 1, Player 2, The Step-Daughter, The Mother

Player 1

- *How do you think the scene is going?*
- *What do you believe good acting is?*
- *What do you fail to notice about the real man beside you?*

Player 2

- *What do you get wrong without knowing it?*
- *What are you proud of in your performance?*
- *What would it take for you to really see her?*

The Step-Daughter

- *What's unbearable about watching them play you?*
- *What do they turn your pain into?*
- *What do you want to shout at them?*

The Mother

- *What does 'It's taking place now' mean to you?*
- *Why can this never be a rehearsal for you?*
- *What is happening in your body as you say it?*

ACT THREE

Part I — The Trap

In it: The Father, The Step-Daughter, The Manager, The Mother

The Father

- *What are you really arguing for when you talk about what's real?*
- *What are you most afraid is true about you?*
- *Who are you trying to convince — them, or yourself?*

The Step-Daughter

- *When do you cut him off — and why then?*
- *What does his philosophy do to your story?*
- *What do you know about him that he won't admit?*

The Manager

- *When does this stop being a game to you?*
- *What unsettles you in what the Father says?*
- *What do you still want to get done tonight?*

The Mother

- *What are you holding onto?*
- *What do the two children mean to you right now?*
- *What do you understand that the clever ones don't?*

Part II — The Refusal

In it: The Son, The Father, The Manager, The Step-Daughter

The Son

- *What will you not do, and why?*
- *What are you protecting by refusing?*
- *What did you see between your parents that you can't unsee?*
- *What would taking part cost you?*

The Father

- *Why do you need him to play it?*
- *What do you feel when your son looks at you?*
- *What are you willing to do to make him?*

The Manager

- *What do you do when an actor refuses?*
- *What do you sense the Son is hiding?*

The Step-Daughter

- *Why are you sure he can't leave?*
- *What do you feel watching him squirm?*

Part III — The Fountain

In it: The Son, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, The Manager

The Son

- *What did you see at the fountain?*
- *Why couldn't you move?*
- *What have you carried since that moment?*

The Mother

- *What do your empty arms know before anyone says it?*
- *What do you want to do and can't?*
- *What is left for you now?*

The Step-Daughter

- *Why do you run?*
- *What can you no longer bear to watch?*
- *Where do you go?*

The Manager

- *Pretence or reality — what do you walk out believing?*
- *What have you just been part of?*
- *Why do you leave?*

What each person should do

You — the Director

Rehearse by unit name (“again, from The Veil”) — it trains the company's memory as much as yours. Read first, talk second. Enforce the first-three-words rule so no one gets handed a line. Keep the Father off the lecture and on the fight.

Assistant Director

Keep the master notes: units named, verbs chosen. Track who is off-book where, so the director knows which scenes can lose the books next week. Flag energy or tone drifting.

Stage Manager / on book

Hold the prompt book and give **only the first three words** on a dry — never the whole line. Note the units into the book. Time the segments; run the stopwatch on the Italian run.

The Father

The biggest load in the play — start now. Learn by your four stages (control, injury, attack, horror): the shape is your memory-map. Action every thought so the Defence plays as panic, not a lecture. Aim to be off-book on Act One first.

The Step-Daughter

The engine and the second-biggest part. Action your cuts cold — evidence, not screaming. Learn your cues off the Father especially; your speed of attack depends on snapping in on his last words. “Valentine” is a wound, not a number.

The Mother

Fewer lines, but each is load-bearing and easy to throw away — learn them by what they cost you, not by rote. “But you drove me away” is the sentence he can never talk you out of. Scored around the object and the veil; say less than you want to.

The Son

Stillness is a presence, not a passivity — every line a door closing. Learn the cues that drag you in against your will. Save the one crack — “somebody must be guilty who did nothing.”

The Manager

The most lines and the most cues in the play — you drive the tempo, so your cue pick-up sets everyone's. Play a director first. Earn the move from “throw them out” to “God help me, it tempts me.” You also hold the comedy timing.

Madame Pace

Only in Act Two, but a full arc in one scene — comic on arrival, chilling by the exit. Learn the broken English exactly as written; the rhythm is the character, and a half-learned accent reads as a mistake, not a choice.

The Players (1 / 2 / 3)

You carry many small cues that keep the machine moving — learn them tight, because a missed Player cue leaves a hole in front of the family's scene. Nervous, not punch-line; be the first to feel the joke die.

Two rules over all of it: test yourself instead of re-reading, and never take the whole line on a dry — the first three words, then retrieve the rest. Understanding first, then memory, then the floor in August. Nothing tonight is fixed; it is being learned.